

Our Man in Havana and the Cold War Image of Cuba

Cold War media was largely a machine for producing enemies. Western news and cinema worked in tandem to establish clear sides: America and its allies as the virtuous, the Soviet bloc and its affiliates as the threat. The American film industry was especially effective at this, churning out spy thrillers and action pictures in which the Russian villain loses, reliably, by the final reel. It is worth asking, then, what happens when a British film gets made inside Cuba itself, with the cooperation of Fidel Castro's newly installed government, during the same period. *Our Man in Havana*, directed by Carol Reed and written by Graham Greene in 1959, is that film. It does not fit the template.

Greene wrote both the screenplay and the novel it adapts. The film went into production just months after Fulgencio Batista's government fell to Castro's rebels, and the new Cuban government welcomed the crew. Castro visited the set during exterior shoots. A title card at the film's opening acknowledges the awkwardness directly: "This film is set in Cuba before the recent Revolution", a disclaimer that signals the filmmakers knew they were navigating something delicate. The story follows Jim Wormold, played by Alec Guinness, a British vacuum salesman in Havana who is recruited by MI6 to run a spy network. Rather than actually recruiting anyone, he invents agents and fabricates intelligence reports, pocketing the payments. The premise is a sustained joke at the expense of British intelligence and its willingness to believe whatever it is told.

The film's antagonist, Captain Segura, is the Cuban counterweight to Wormold's bumbling. He is a senior military officer who wants to marry Wormold's daughter and grows increasingly suspicious of him. On paper, Segura is the obstacle, the local authority bearing down on the foreign spy. In practice, he is one of the more composed and perceptive characters in the film. He is not menacing so much as methodical, and the film treats him with a degree of respect it never extends to the British government. The Cuban Ministry of Culture apparently noticed this and asked Reed to make Segura more villainous. Reed did not comply in any meaningful way. That the new Castro government lobbied for a harsher portrayal of its own military official in a foreign film is a strange footnote, and it says something about how the film was being read at the time.

Greene chose Cuba deliberately. By 1959, the country had become globally significant, a small island that had just reoriented itself toward the Soviet Union and suddenly mattered to the nuclear calculus of the Cold War. Writing about Cuba was not incidental; it was writing about the center of something. Bosley Crowther, reviewing the film for the *New York Times* in 1960, asked whether it offered a fair reflection of the climate in that nervous capital. The question is a good one, and Greene does not exactly answer it. The film is partly a satire of British espionage culture, partly a meditation on how intelligence services create the threats they claim to be managing, and only loosely a film about Cuba at all. Havana functions more as atmosphere than subject.

Visually, the city is presented without hostility. It looks alive and functional, its streets populated by people going about ordinary business. This is not nothing. Most western productions of the era would have found ways to make an adversarial country look diminished, chaotic, or threatening. *Our Man in Havana* declines to do that. The film's anxieties are real —

Reed is aware of the atomic tension underwriting everything, but he filters them through irony rather than alarm. The result is a spy film that takes seriously the absurdity of the genre and, by extension, the absurdity of the Cold War itself.

The film's most telling scene comes about an hour in. Wormold is brought to the police station after Segura has been tailing him. Segura questions him about several deaths connected to people in Wormold's orbit, pressing without ever raising his voice. The interrogation ends with Segura asking Wormold if he plays checkers. It is an elegant encapsulation of what their relationship actually is: a game with two possible outcomes, neither of them violent. As Wormold leaves, Segura moves a piece forward on the board and he is ahead, for now. The scene works as drama and as metaphor. England and Cuba were not shooting at each other. They were moving pieces.

A scene shortly after complicates the picture. Segura, in conversation with Wormold and another British operative, touches briefly on the subject of torture. When asked whether a particular man was tortured to obtain information, Segura explains that that man belongs to a class of people they do not torture. They only torture the poor. The exchange is delivered casually, almost as an aside, and the film moves on without comment. It is the most direct moment of moral darkness in the entire picture, and Greene places it in the mouth of the character the film has otherwise treated most generously. The implication is not hammered home. It simply sits there.

From Russia With Love, released in 1963, provides a useful contrast. Directed by Terence Young and four years removed from *Our Man in Havana*, it is everything Greene's film is not: aggressively pro-British, unambiguous about who the enemy is, and constructed around the premise that the west is right and the Soviets are wrong. The Bond franchise codified a set of conventions that shaped espionage cinema for decades, conventions that *Our Man in Havana* quietly refuses. Greene is not interested in designating a correct side. His British bureaucrats are credulous and self-important; his Cuban officer is sharp and not entirely wrong. The film does not flatter anyone, but it distributes its skepticism evenly.

Our Man in Havana is a minor film that repays attention precisely because it resists the logic of its moment. In 1959, with the Cold War accelerating and the Bond era about to begin, the default mode for western spy entertainment was moral clarity: us versus them, civilization versus the threat. Greene wrote something messier and more honest. Cuba in the film is neither villainized nor idealized. It is a place where power operates in familiar ways, where a smart officer can see through a bad cover story, and where the real comedy is not the enemy's incompetence but the west's self-regard. That the Cuban government wanted the film to be harsher on Cuba than it was is, finally, the most interesting thing about it.